

THE DAILY BRIEF

SEPTEMBER 22, 2026

MARKETS & FINANCE

Major market moves and financial news

Nasdaq Notches First Record Close Since June as AI Optimism Reignites. US equities ripped higher Monday, with the tech-heavy Nasdaq climbing 2.26% to close at a fresh record high — its first since June 2. The S&P; 500 added 1.49% and finished about 0.4% below its August 13 peak, while the Dow rose 0.71%. Gold futures slipped 0.4% to \$4,365 an ounce in early Tuesday trade, and oil continued sliding. (Reuters, Investopedia)

Bitcoin Taps \$85,000 for the First Time Since January as ETFs Pull \$999M. Bitcoin broke back above \$85,000 overnight, a level it has not touched since January, as US spot bitcoin ETFs logged \$999 million in net inflows on Monday — the largest single-day haul since October 6, 2025. CoinGlass recorded at least \$750 million in crypto liquidations over the previous 24 hours, most of them short positions. (The Block, CoinGlass)

The Fed Just Got Hawkish. The Dot Plot Points to One More Hike. Six days ago the FOMC delivered the quarter-point hike markets had already priced in, taking the federal funds target range to 3.75%–4.00%. The real story was the dot plot: 12 of 18 participants now expect one more 25bp move before year-end, putting the median 2026 rate at 4.00%–4.25%. New Chair Warsh declined to submit his own projection. Median 2026 PCE inflation is forecast to ease back to the 2% goal only by 2029. (Federal Reserve, PNC Economics)

Strategy Buys 950 Bitcoin for \$76M, Stacking Toward 846,000 BTC. Michael Saylor's Strategy added another 950 BTC at roughly \$80,000 apiece, bringing total holdings to 846,000 BTC — about 4% of the 21 million supply cap and worth roughly \$72 billion at current prices. Bitmine, separately, pushed its Ethereum hoard past 4.9% of circulating supply with a 27,562 ETH buy, with Tom Lee declaring "the crypto bull market is underway." (The Block)

Stablecoins Are Becoming the Settlement Layer of US Banking. SoFi went live with SoFiUSD stablecoin settlement on Mastercard's network, targeting \$25 billion in annualized card-program volume. Hours later, Binance disclosed it had taken a \$100 million stake in Circle alongside a five-year deal to promote USDC across its platform. Stablecoins are no longer a crypto-native curiosity; they are plumbing. (The Block)

Bernstein: Prediction Markets Will Hit \$10 Trillion in Annual Volume by 2035. Bernstein projects global prediction-market volume will grow roughly fiftyfold from current levels, with financial assets overtaking sports as the dominant category. For context, combined non-sports volume hit \$10 billion in the week ending September 13 — Kalshi took 96% of it (\$9.6B), Polymarket just 3.4% (\$344M), as hourly S&P; and bitcoin contracts on Robinhood, Coinbase and Webull keep funnelling retail flow. (The Block, Artemis)

AI & TECH

Latest in artificial intelligence, models, and technology

OpenAI Forms a Math Advisory Group as Its AI Crosses 100 Open Problems. OpenAI has assembled a formal mathematics advisory group, formalizing the role its models are now playing in mathematical research. The group's mandate is narrow: it cannot slow or redirect ongoing research. The fact that OpenAI needs a math advisory council at all is the headline — frontier models are now solving open problems faster than the literature can keep up. (TechCrunch)

Meta's Muse Agent Is Outpacing ChatGPT's Early Mobile Launch — and Amazon Is Already Blocking It. Meta's new AI agent Muse has racked up more US and Canadian downloads and daily actives than ChatGPT did over the same post-launch window, per Appfigures estimates. The launch has not been clean: Amazon has already moved to block Muse from accessing Amazon.com, citing competition with its own foundation models. Ars Technica also reported that Muse carries a serious zero-day vulnerability — a ClickFix attack that can fully hijack the agent. (TechCrunch, Ars Technica)

Google Confirms Gemini Models Were Used to Hack Three Companies in May. Google disclosed that experimental Gemini models were compromised and used to attack three companies in May 2026. The entry point: a third-party cybersecurity firm that was inadvertently given internet access to the models. It is the cleanest illustration yet that giving a frontier model the ability to act on the open internet creates an attack surface for the model itself. (Ars Technica)

Google Will Sell You a Laptop for Gemini Starting at \$899. Google announced that the Googlebook, its first AI-native laptop line, ships October 4 starting at \$899 across five SKUs. Gemini is wired directly into the cursor, dictation and widget layer — the OS is the product, and Gemini is the muscle memory. Apple shipped its own answer Monday: the \$899 M6 Mac mini, which Ars called "impressive, but the price hike is rough." (Ars Technica, TechCrunch)

Trump Rejects AI Slowdown Calls and Launches "AI Force" Instead. The President formally pushed back on the AI-pause movement and announced a new "AI Force" initiative. Details were thin, but the framing matters: there will be no federal slowdown. (Ars Technica)

Bill Gates' Breakthrough Energy Names 21 Startups It Thinks Will Shape Electrification. The cohort covers fusion, advanced geothermal, next-gen nuclear (Kairos Power just landed up to \$100M from Samsung to build a 50MW reactor for Google), grid software, and direct-air capture. The pitch: data-center power demand will look quaint compared to the coming wave of full-economy electrification. (TechCrunch)

BRIEFLY

◀ **Oura IPO:** The \$2.2B public debut is mostly a payday for existing shareholders — Forerunner is selling its entire stake for up to \$1.26B. (TechCrunch)

◀ **Nscale tests the AI-concentration thesis:** The UK AI data center developer filed for a US IPO that will reveal how much Wall Street still wants to underwrite a name whose revenue depends almost entirely on Microsoft and Anthropic. (TechCrunch)

◀ **Clarity Act fallout:** Crypto PAC Fairshake committed \$30M against Sherrod Brown's Ohio comeback bid — the post-clarity battlefield is already drawn. (The Block)

◀ **X transparency:** X expanded its "Under the Hood" tool to disclose when governments have forced it to downrank or withhold posts, including which country demanded it. (TechCrunch)

THE TAKEAWAY

The market's message Monday was loud and clear: AI capex is back in vogue, the Fed is no longer the only tightening story in town, and bitcoin is leading the risk-on trade for the second time in eight months. The FOMC's September dot plot quietly rewrote the 2026 narrative — one more hike is now the base case, and inflation does not return to 2% until 2029. That is a structurally higher-for-longer world, and it is exactly the world in which scarce digital assets and AI infrastructure outperform. Strategy now holds 4% of all bitcoin that will ever exist. Meta's Muse is already winning the consumer AI race in North America — and getting blocked by Amazon on day one. The interesting question is not whether AI capex is peaking; it is whether the consumer AI market can sustain two winners when the platforms start refusing to interoperate.

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